

Your First Optimized Page

Everything from Tier 1, applied to one real page, end to end.

Bottom line

This is the section where Tier 1 stops being theory. You take one cluster from your keyword map and build or rebuild the page that owns it, in a fixed order that puts the decisions that cannot be undone cheaply first. Do it once carefully here and it becomes the repeatable process Tier 2 refines.

Pick the right page to start with

Not your homepage. Not your hardest target.

From your keyword map, choose a cluster that is:

- **High on relevance x intent value**, so the work matters commercially
- **Has click availability**, from your Section 5 check
- **Winnable**, ideally one where your manual difficulty read found something weak on page one
- **Either an existing page that needs work, or a straightforward new page**

Commercial investigation intent is usually the sweet spot for a services business: real buying signal, and the answer requires a decision, so the click survives the AI layer.

The order matters

Work in this sequence. Each step constrains the next, and reversing them causes rework.

1. Confirm the intent. Search the primary query again. Look at the top ten. What content type dominates, and what shape do the titles take? You are building that shape, not the shape you imagined.

2. Decide the page's job. One sentence: "This page helps someone who is [situation] make [decision] by [what it provides]." If you cannot write that sentence, you are not ready to write the page.

3. Outline against the SERP and the cluster. Open the top three results and the People Also Ask box. List every sub-question they answer. Your outline must cover the ground the cluster represents plus anything the top results miss. **Covering what they miss is the only reason to expect to outrank them.**

4. Write the content. Answer the primary question early and directly, then go deeper. Do not warm up for four paragraphs. Both human readers and AI extraction reward the answer appearing near the

top.

5. Then do the on-page elements. Title, meta description, headings, URL, images, internal links. These are last on purpose. Optimizing metadata for a page whose content is wrong is polishing the wrong object.

The on-page checklist

Tier 2 covers each of these in depth. Here is the working version for your first page.

Element	Target
Title tag	50 to 60 characters, primary query in the first 40, matches the format the SERP rewards
URL	short, lowercase, hyphens, the main term, under 60 characters. Never change an existing URL just to optimize it
H1	exactly one, containing the primary query, close to the title but not identical
Meta description	105 to 155 characters, key information in the first 120. Not a ranking factor, it is your CTR pitch
H2s and H3s	one per sub-question. Phrase several as direct questions , which improves featured snippet and AI citation odds
Opening	answer the query in the first 40 to 60 words. Bottom line up front
Body	covers every secondary query in the cluster naturally. No keyword stuffing, no word-count target
Images	descriptive alt text, compressed, hero under 150KB, WebP or AVIF
Internal links	8 to 15 per 2,000 words, specific anchor text, never "click here"
Evidence	at least one statistic, expert quote, or cited source. The Princeton GEO study measured these raising AI citation probability 30 to 41%

The extractability pass

New in 2026 and worth doing on your first page so it becomes habit.

AI engines retrieve at passage level, not page level. Structure so that individual sections stand alone:

- **Self-contained answer units of roughly 134 to 167 words.** A section that makes sense lifted out of the page. [practitioner]
- **Define the entity in the first 40 to 60 words** of a section rather than referring back to "it" and "this". [practitioner]
- **Front-load conclusions.** Bottom line, then support.
- **Use tables and lists** where the content is genuinely comparative or sequential. They extract cleanly.

None of this conflicts with writing well for humans. It is mostly the same discipline: say the thing, then explain it.

What not to do

- **Do not write to a word count.** Length is not a ranking factor. Cover the ground and stop.
- **Do not repeat the keyword.** Keyword density is not a thing and has not been for years.
- **Do not change existing URLs** for cosmetic reasons. You inherit redirect complexity and risk losing signals for negligible gain.
- **Do not target three intents on one page.** You will satisfy none of them.
- **Do not publish and move on.** Section 19 covers the update cycle, and AI-cited content runs about 25.7% fresher than uncited content.

Verify before you publish

- 1 Read it aloud. If a sentence is hard to say, rewrite it.
- 2 Does it answer the primary query in the first paragraph?
- 3 Could each H2 section stand alone as an answer?
- 4 Does it cover every secondary query in the cluster?
- 5 Does it say something the top three results do not?
- 6 Is there at least one piece of concrete evidence?
- 7 Does the title match the format the SERP is rewarding?

After publishing

- **Request indexing** in Search Console URL Inspection. It does not guarantee speed, but it queues the URL.
- **Link to it** from at least two existing relevant pages immediately. New pages with no internal links are effectively orphans.

- **Record the date and the baseline.** Position, impressions and clicks today, so you can measure movement.
- **Wait.** Meaningful movement takes weeks, not days. Section 3 explains why judging early means judging noise.

Why this matters

most people never do this deliberately, even once. They write, then retrofit a title, then wonder why it did not work. Doing it in the right order once teaches you the order, and the order is the transferable part.

Do this now

- 1 **Pick the cluster** from your keyword map using the criteria above.
- 2 **Re-search the primary query** and note the dominant content type and title format.
- 3 **Write the one-sentence job statement** for the page.
- 4 **Outline from the top three results plus People Also Ask**, and mark at least one thing you will cover that they do not.
- 5 **Write or rewrite the content**, answer first.
- 6 **Work the on-page checklist** in order.
- 7 **Run the extractability pass**: self-contained sections, entity defined early, conclusions front-loaded.
- 8 **Run the seven verification questions.**
- 9 **Publish, request indexing, add two internal links, record the baseline date and metrics.**

Capstone step

The most important page on your capstone site is now genuinely optimized against a real cluster, with a recorded baseline. Everything in Tier 2 is a refinement of what you just did once by hand.

Key takeaways

- Order matters: intent, then job, then outline, then content, then on-page elements. Metadata last, because polishing a page with the wrong content is wasted work.
- The only reason to expect to outrank the top three is covering something they do not. Decide what that is before writing.
- Answer the query in the first 40 to 60 words, and build sections that stand alone in roughly 134 to 167 words so passage-level retrieval can lift them.
- Publish, link internally, record a baseline, then wait. Judging in the first week is judging noise.